

Water disruption

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QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

After a water outage, damaged pipes or suspected contamination, use sealed bottled or previously stored safe water until you establish the risk. Boil-water, do-not-drink and do-not-use notices mean different things. Boiling kills germs but does not remove fuel, chemicals or radioactive contamination. If notices are unavailable, do not treat clear water or restored pressure as proof of safety.

Do now.

- ☐ **Identify the notice**
01 Find the utility or health department notice for your address, its start time, reason, and permitted uses. Save a screenshot in case service fails.
- ☐ **Match use to the instruction**
02 A boil-water notice generally addresses microbes; follow the authority's boil directions. If the notice says do not drink or do not use, follow those stricter limits and the specified alternative-water instructions.
- ☐ **Protect priority needs**
03 Set aside approved water for drinking, infant formula, medications, tooth brushing, food preparation, and pets, as the notice directs.
- ☐ **Wait for clearance**
04 Do not assume that water is safe because it looks clear or service has returned. Follow flushing or filter replacement instructions after an official all-clear.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If there is no notice after pressure loss, flooding or damaged pipes, use sealed or previously stored safe water while you establish the risk. Do not assume that boiling solves an unknown contamination problem. Label containers and keep drinking water separate from cleaning water.

Watch for.

Do not boil water suspected of chemical or fuel contamination. Boiling can concentrate some contaminants; use the alternative source named in the notice.

People & practical needs.

Include drinking, medicines, infant feeding and food preparation in the safe-water plan. Tell every caregiver which container is clean and which tap uses are restricted. Consider people who cannot read the warning or lift a large container.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Store water and a printed copy of your utility's alert channel. Know whether anyone in the household needs extra water or cannot use a typical treatment method.

Check the next usable option

Store water and a printed copy of your utility's alert channel. Know whether anyone in the household needs extra water or cannot use a typical treatment method.

When the first option is unavailable

If there is no notice after pressure loss, flooding or damaged pipes, use sealed or previously stored safe water while you establish the risk. Do not assume that boiling solves an unknown contamination problem. Label containers and keep drinking water separate from cleaning water.

Questions in the field.

What does the notice actually restrict?

Read its name and affected area: boil-water, do-not-drink and do-not-use notices have different consequences. If the reason is unknown, do not assume a filter or boiling resolves it. Use a verified alternate drinking source while checking the restriction.

Someone already drank suspect water - now what?

Record the source and time and seek medical or poison guidance when reachable, especially after a chemical warning or new symptoms. Do not induce vomiting or give an improvised treatment. Severe symptoms need urgent care rather than a water-treatment tutorial.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

[CDC · Drinking water advisories](#)

<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/about/drinking-water-advisories-an-overview.html>

[CDC · Make water safe in an emergency](#)

<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/about/index.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/water-disruption/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.